

# Local manufacturing for quality control

In conversation with Ambrane's  
**Ashok Rajpal**

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**A**mbrane is a known brand in the Indian consumer tech space. What began as an Rs 10 lakh experiment is now a scaled accessories business competing across power, charging and lifestyle categories. In this conversation, Ambrane Co-Founder and Managing Director, Mr Ashok Rajpal, reflects on the different phases of growth, from cracking distribution to choosing manufacturing early. He explains how market timing, hands-on consumer learning and local production shaped the brand's strategy, and why reliability, after-sales support and steady iteration matter more than aggressive marketing in building long-term trust with Indian consumers.

**Q Ambrane began as a Rs 10 lakh start-up and is now one of the most popular mobile accessories brands in India. What were some of the toughest phases in that journey, and what did you get right at the right time?**

**A Ashok:** When we started Ambrane, which is now a 14-year-old journey, the category itself was still evolving. In the early days, distribution was the biggest challenge. Penetrating the traditional retail market was very tough. At the same time, online marketplaces helped us grow significantly during the initial phase. I would say the traditional markets were difficult to crack, but online channels supported our growth a lot in the early years.

**Q What made you start this journey? What was the prime motivation behind entering this segment?**

**A Ashok:** Around the year 2000, mobile phones became the biggest technological revolution of our time. Smartphones started becoming accessible, and people began adopting technology very quickly. Seeing this shift, we were keen to enter the market and understand consumer behaviour. Initially, we started small. We opened a shop in a local area to understand the customer mindset, expectations, product needs, and features. That learning phase motivated us to enter this segment seriously.

**Q How do user scenarios like travel, commuting, and multi-device use shape your product design decisions?**

**A Ashok:** We have a strong R&D team, along with dedicated design and product teams. All these teams spend time in the market to understand requirements and identify what features customers expect. Many people in our organisation belong to Gen Z, so they are very aware of lifestyle usage patterns. They actively contribute inputs on how a product should ideally fit into daily life. This internal feedback helps us make products that are practical, logical, and relevant for consumers.



**Ashok Rajpal**  
Co-Founder and  
Managing Director,  
Ambrane

**Q How do you think about practical differences when designing for such a diverse user base?**

**A Ashok:** Most technologies in this category are initially driven by Apple, but we ensure that products are tested and validated across platforms, including Samsung and other Androids. Validation takes four to six months before a product launches. Only after thorough testing across devices does a product come to market.

**Q How has local manufacturing changed cost structures, agility, and product quality?**

**A Ashok:** Local manufacturing gives us much greater control over quality. Indian consumers today are very informed. They research products, features, and specifications thoroughly. Because of this, continuous product upgrades are necessary. Manufacturing locally allows us to implement changes quickly. It also strengthens the supply chain, reduces lead times, and lets us serve the market faster.

When manufacturing is done in-house and at scale, it helps control pricing, making products affordable.

**Q How's competition from low-cost Chinese imports?**

**A Ashok:** There are two types of markets globally. One is the organised brand market, and the other is the unorganised market. We do not compete with the unorganised segment. In the brand market, we are comfortable competing because we offer better quality, controlled manufacturing, and reliable supply chains. ■

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